The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

Donald Trump said he was considering “winding down” the war against **Iran** because America was “very close” to meeting its aims. Mr Trump also argued that the Strait of Hormuz should be policed by countries “who use it”, not America. Earlier the president said he did not want a ceasefire with Iran. The Pentagon also ordered the deployment of more troops to the Middle East.

America lifted sanctions on some **Iranian oil** in an attempt to calm volatile energy markets. Scott Bessent, America’s treasury secretary, said the Trump administration would temporarily permit the sale of Iranian oil and petroleum products that are already loaded on ships. On Friday the price of Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, settled at around $112 a barrel.

Meanwhile **American stocks** fell. The S&P 500 and the NASDAQ closed 1.5% and 2% lower respectively. The **International Energy Agency**, an intergovernmental organisation, recommended that people work from home as an emergency response to the “largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market”. It also suggested car sharing and avoiding air travel.

NATO said it withdrew all personnel from its mission in **Iraq** and moved them to Italy. Its base was located near America’s embassy

in Baghdad, which has repeatedly been targeted by Iranian strikes. The non-combat mission, which was created in 2018, assists Iraq with counter-terrorism efforts that include preventing the return of Islamic State.

Colombia's president, **Gustavo Petro**, is being investigated by American criminal prosecutors over alleged connections to drug traffickers, according to media reports. The drug probe apparently spans wider than Mr Petro; an unnamed source told Reuters that it was not "squarely focused on him". Mr Trump has previously called Mr Petro an "illegal drug trafficker", an accusation he denies.

ByteDance, the Chinese owner of TikTok, reached an agreement to sell Moonton, a gaming studio, to Savvy Games Group, a subsidiary of Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund, for around $6bn. ByteDance paid $4bn for the business in 2021. The sale marks the company's exit from the **gaming market**, where it failed to compete with larger Chinese rivals such as Tencent.

Chuck Norris died at the age of 86. The martial-arts star had his cinema debut alongside Bruce Lee in "The Way of the Dragon" in 1972; he later acted in the TV series "Walker, Texas Ranger". His popularity took off again in the 2000s with Chuck Norris facts, deadpan memes about his exaggerated toughness. Tributes came from fellow actors Sylvester Stallone and Jean-Claude Van Damme.

Word of the week: Chinamaxxing, a social media trend whereby young Westerners adopt Chinese habits like drinking hot water or Tsingtao beer. Read our report on increasingly favourable views of China in the west, and why the feeling is not mutual.

Figure of the day: 7.2%, the amount by which Cuba's GDP is forecast to shrink in 2026. Read the full story.

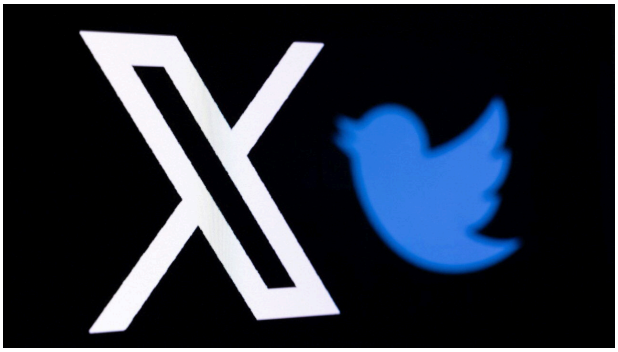
Photograph: Reuters

A tale of two wars

As the fighting ravaging the Middle East enters its fourth week, there is no obvious way to end it. America and Israel have battered Iran's armed forces, assassinated several of Iran's most powerful politicians and sunk more than 100 ships. That could have been grounds for Mr Trump to declare victory already.

But America's president seems increasingly focused on the other war, which Iran is waging in parallel—against the world economy. Mr Trump appears frustrated by his inability to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, and to stop Iran's escalating attacks on oilfields and energy-production facilities in the region.

The Gulf states have not joined the fight. But, having borne the brunt of Iran's retaliation, most now want to see its regime crippled. Their message to Mr Trump has been that the war cannot end with an emboldened Iran able to hold their economies hostage. America, Israel and the Gulf states started the war with different aims—but Iran is pushing them into alignment.



Photograph: Getty Images

Twenty years of tweeting

“Just setting up my twttr,” posted Jack Dorsey, Twitter’s co-founder, on March 21st 2006. Two decades later, over half a billion posts are sent on the service every day. The social-media platform has evolved from a what-I-had-for-breakfast app into perhaps the world’s most influential real-time news machine, powering events from the Arab Spring to the rise of Donald Trump. Twitter inventions like the hashtag and the retweet have become digital standards.

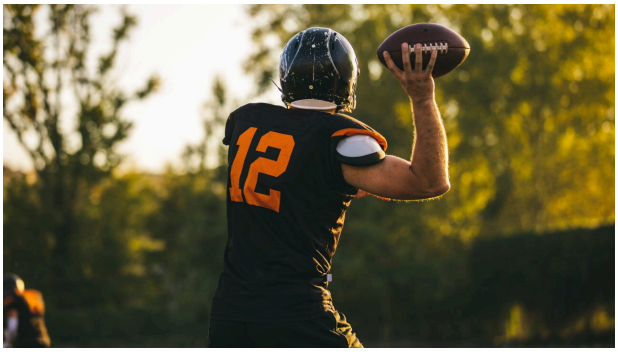
Since Elon Musk bought the company for $44bn in 2022 and later renamed it X, the platform has transformed. He laid off 80% of staff and loosened moderation rules, leading to an advertiser exodus and a drop in the firm’s valuation, to $19bn. Now regulators are on its case. In December the European Commission fined it €120m over “deceptive design practices”, including its blue-checkmark system (X is appealing). Britain and the EU are investigating its role in the spread of non-consensual AI images. Still, its users are posting through it.

Photograph: Netflix

The Red Hot Chili Peppers reflect on their past

The Red Hot Chili Peppers redefined southern California sound in the 1980s, blending hardcore, punk and hip-hop into up-tempo bangers that dared listeners to stay seated. It helped that their two frontmen, singer Anthony Kiedis and bassist Flea, had remarkable stage presence. Their 1991 album “Blood Sugar Sex Magik” is the sound of high school for certain Gen Xers; “Californication”, released eight years later, was their biggest hit, selling more than 10m copies.

A new documentary, “The Rise of the Red Hot Chili Peppers: Our Brother, Hillel”, traces their earliest days. The band formed in high school. The crucial member, as both Flea and Mr Kiedis attest, was their friend Hillel Slovak, a guitarist who died of a heroin overdose in 1988, just as the band was finding its feet. Fans will love everything about this film. But the two frontmen are self-aware and entertaining enough that even those who never stepped into a mosh pit will find themselves smiling.

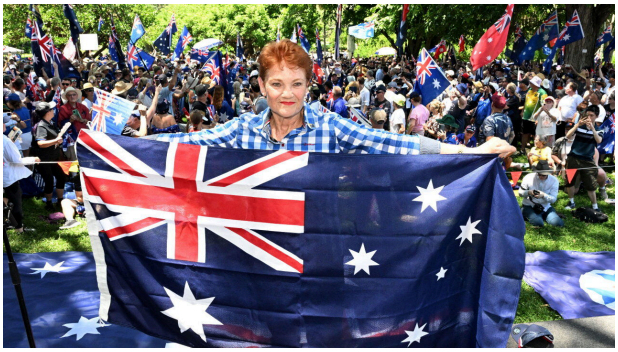


Photograph: Getty Images

The cost of a concussion

For many athletes who play contact sports, the risks do not end with the final whistle. In some cases the physical toll can be lethal. American football players die from neurodegenerative diseases at three times the rate of the general population. One of the best-known is chronic traumatic encephalopathy (CTE), an illness triggered by repeated head injuries.

CTE is poorly understood, and shows up only in post-mortem examinations. But a new study may offer clues. Researchers examined the MRI scans of 47 former athletes (most of whom had been rugby players and boxers), finding that disruption to the blood-brain barrier lingered for an average of 12 years after they retired. Such damage, the researchers said, lets peripheral immune cells and blood proteins leach into brain tissue, with destructive consequences. Their findings showed that athletes with the most compromised barriers suffered the steepest cognitive declines, struggling with memory and executive function.



Photograph: Alamy

Weekend profile: Pauline Hanson, champion of Australia's populist-right

Last Halloween Australia's Pauline Hanson was embraced by the inner sanctum of the global populist-right—with an invite to Donald Trump's Great Gatsby-themed party at Mar-a-Lago. Ms Hanson, a former owner of a fish and chip shop in suburban Brisbane, has come far in her political career. Now, after decades spent struggling to translate her profile into seats in parliament, the red-haired 71-year-old may be on the cusp of a breakthrough.

Ms Hanson's hardline anti-immigration views defined her career long before they gained momentum elsewhere. She won pre-selection as a candidate for the conservative Liberal Party in the 1996 federal election, but lost her endorsement for making disparaging remarks about Aboriginal people. It didn't matter: she won the seat and sat as an independent, warning in her maiden speech that Australia was at risk of being "swamped by Asians". The following year Ms Hanson founded her personal political vehicle: One Nation.

The party only enjoyed limited electoral success, but Ms Hanson has projected outsize influence on Australian politics. Many credit her with pushing the Liberal-National coalition government of John Howard, a long-serving conservative prime minister, to the right in the late 1990s and early 2000s: it implemented more severe asylum

policies, including offshore detention, which have become the gold standard for Europe's right.

Jailed in 2003 for electoral fraud (a conviction later overturned), Ms Hanson faded into political obscurity and had a brief reality-television career. But she was elected to the Senate in 2016, this time claiming the country was "in danger of being swamped by Muslims". She campaigned against halal certification and the burka. Recently she suggested there were no "good Muslims" and claimed Lakemba, a suburb of Sydney where six in ten people are Muslim, was a "no-go zone" for "ordinary Australians"; the local mosque subsequently received threats of violence.

Ms Hanson's message found resonance after Islamic State-inspired terrorists killed 15 people who were celebrating the Jewish festival of Hanukkah at Bondi Beach in December. Dysfunction in Australia's centre-right parties has pushed swathes of conservative voters toward One Nation: it is now running ahead of both the Liberal and National parties in the polls, and close to the governing Labor party.

Mr Howard dismissively attributes One Nation's "temporary surge in the polls" to unhappiness with the Liberals. South Australia's state election this weekend is the first test of whether the elder statesman is correct. It is generally considered more moderate than Ms Hanson's native Queensland in the country's north-east. Yet even in South Australia, One Nation is outpolling the Liberals. If that translates into votes, One Nation could replace the centre-right party as the official opposition—pushing the Australian right into uncharted territory.

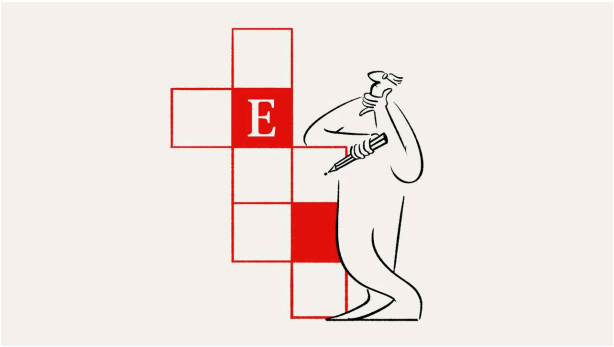


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the grid below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Office manager is kind of crude (5)

2 across - Academia might contain somewhere sunny (5)

3 across - Swiftian human search engine (5)

1 down - London neighbourhood flowers into ruby arrangement (10)

Straight clues

1 across - An oilfield in the North Sea that gives its name to an oil-price benchmark (5)

2 across - Big city in southern Florida (5)

3 across - What Jonathan Swift called “a brute in human form” (5)

1 down - The London neighbourhood from which a set of modernist writers took their name (10)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Bill Greggs, Birmingham, England

Eli Powell, Roswell, Georgia, America

Linda Bonger, Zurich, Switzerland

They all gave the correct answers of: Ripley; The Hunting of the Snark; Ryan Gosling; Ultimatum; Martian Chronicles.

The theme is movies starring Matt Damon: "The Talented Mr Ripley"; "Good Will Hunting", "Saving Private Ryan"; "The Bourne Ultimatum" "The Martian".

The questions were:

Monday: Which character is portrayed by Sigourney Weaver in the Alien films?

Tuesday: The Bellman is a key character in which Lewis Carroll poem?

Wednesday: Which actor played Ken in the Barbie live action movie?

Thursday: What word is used for a demand that must be met within a set period of time?

Friday: Which 1950 novel by Ray Bradbury is set on another planet?

If you don’t like someone’s story, write your own.

Chinua Achebe